

Promises and Pressure: The Second Attempt

承诺与压力：第二次尝试

Theme: 友谊、家庭与人际关系 · New: 45 · Review: 18 · Planned cumulative progress: 45/6, 127

English Story

The second attempt began with a **funeral** and a **birthday** in the same week. The **cousin** of his **former wife**, a **tall actor** and a convinced **optimist** with an unlikely **surname**, came to the house, and the family had to decide who would sit where. “**You** are a **saint**,” his aunt said. He was not. He was a **pessimist** with an appointment with the **dentist**, and he said so. Her **son**, a boy of nine, was there with his own question about the ceremony: he wanted to know whether a family could be chosen rather than given.

They were **wed** in a **small** ceremony in the **nursery** garden, and the **bride** carried a bunch of flowers instead of a **doll**. The **bridegroom**, a **salesman** from the next town, had a **regular** job and an **infinite** patience for children. “**Whoever** adopts a **surname** in this family,” the grandmother said, “adopts a history.”

The **husband** of his **cousin** was a young **giant** of a man who worked with cows and could lift a calf. “**She** is my **grandchild**,” the grandmother said, “and so are the other **grandchildren**.” A **nasty pill**, a **small creature**, a **youngster** with a blue bicycle, an **ethnic** dish on the table, and a **bitch** with three puppies in the yard: the house was full of them **throughout** the afternoon. A little of something was always missing, and the head of the table never let it show.

At the **initial** meeting of the family council, **they** were asked to say what **they** expected. “We cannot control who marries whom,” Maya said. “But we can see that six people are not asked to carry one person's part.” The **latter** remark was, however, the one that stuck, and the figure on the whiteboard was not the real figure at all.

So the second attempt was smaller and more **regular**. I **myself** wrote the schedule; we allowed **ourselves** one evening a week; a **homosexual** couple in the building lent us their table and their kettle. “Yeah,” Maya said, “so that is the great reform: a table, an honest name, and nobody pretending that a family is a fixed thing.”

中文翻译

第二次尝试以同一周里的一场葬礼和一个生日开始。他前妻的表亲，一位高个子的男演员、一个坚定的乐观主义者，带着一个不太可能的姓氏来到家里，而全家人必须决定谁坐在哪里。“你是个圣人，”他姑妈说。他不是。他是一个带着牙医预约的悲观主义者，而且他当面说了出来。她的儿子，一个九岁的男孩，也在场，带着他自己关于仪式的疑问：他想知道，一个家庭是可以挑选的，还是只能被给予的。

他们在一座小苗圃花园里举行了小规模婚礼，新娘手里捧着一束花而不是一个洋娃娃。新郎是邻镇的推销员，有一份稳定的工作和对孩子无限的耐心。“在这个家里，谁采用了一个姓氏，”祖母说，“就是采用了一段历史。”

他表姐的丈夫是个年轻的巨人，与牛打交道，能举起一头小牛。“她是我的孙辈，”祖母说，“其他的孙辈也一样。”一颗难吃的药丸、一只小小的生物、一个推着蓝色自行车的少年、桌上的一道民族菜肴，以及院子里一只带着三只幼崽的母狗：整个下午屋子里都是他们。总有一点点什么东西是缺的，而坐在上首的人从不让它显露出来。

在家庭委员会的首次会议上，他们被要求说出自己的期待。“我们无法控制谁和谁结婚，”曼雅说，“但我们能看到，不能让六个人去承担一个人的那份。”然而，真正留下的是后半句；白板上的那个数字根本不是真正的数字。

于是第二次尝试变得更小、更有规律。我自己写了时间表；我们允许自己每周有一个晚上；楼里一对同性恋伴侣把他们的桌子和水壶借给了我们。“是的，”曼雅说，“所以这就是伟大的改革：一张桌子、一个诚实的名字，以及没有人再假装家庭是一件固定不变的东西。”

Core Vocabulary · 核心词汇

Word / Pronunciation	Context meaning / source example
you ju: POS: pron	pron. 你, 你们 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: dat. & obj. The pronoun of the second person, in the nominative,; dative, and objective case, indicating th...
they ðei POS: pron	pron. 他们, 它们 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: obj. The plural of he, she, or it. They is never used; adjectively, but always as a pronoun proper, and som...
she ʃi: POS: pron	pron. 她 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: obj. This or that female; the woman understood or referred to;; the animal of the female sex, or object per...
small smɔ:l POS: a	a. 小的, 少的, 小型的, 低微的, 小气的, 细微的; adv. 些微地; n. 狭小部分 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. the slender part of the back; n. a garment size for a small person; a. limited or below average in number or...
former 'fɔ:mə POS: a	a. 从前的, 前者的; n. 起形成作用的人(或物), 模型, 样板 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. the first of two or the first mentioned of two; a. referring to the first of two things or persons mentione...
wife waɪf POS: n	n. 妻子, 太太, 夫人; [法] 妻子, 已婚妇女 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a married woman; a man's partner in marriage
son sʌn POS: n	n. 儿子, 女婿, 子孙; [法] 儿子, 女婿, 养子 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a male human offspring; n. the divine word of God; the second person in the Trinity (incarnate in Jesus)
husband 'hʌzbənd POS: n	n. 丈夫, 管理人, 节俭的人; vt. 节俭, 使成丈夫, 持有 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a married man; a woman's partner in marriage
myself maɪ'self POS: pron	pron. 我自己, 我亲自, 我独自 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: pron. I or me in person; -- used for emphasis, my own self or; person; as I myself will do it; I have done...
throughout θru:'aʊt POS: adv	adv. 到处, 贯穿全部地, 自始至终; prep. 遍及, 在各处; [计] 吞吐量 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: r. from first to last
adopt ə'dɒpt POS: vt	vt. 采用, 正式通过, 收养, 接受; [医] 采取 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: v. choose and follow; as of theories, ideas, policies, strategies or plans; v. take up and practice as one's o...
marry 'mæri POS: vt	vt. 与...结婚, 娶, 嫁; vi. 结婚 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: v. take in marriage; v. perform a marriage ceremony
latter 'lætə POS: a	a. 后者的, 较后的, 近来的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. the second of two or the second mentioned of two; a. referring to the second of two things or persons menti...
regular 'regjələ POS: a	a. 规则的, 常规的, 有秩序的, 整齐的, 等边的, 定期的, 经常的, 合格的, 常备军的; n. 正规军, 正式队员; adv. 经常... Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a regular patron; n. a soldier in the regular army; n. a dependable follower (especially in party politics); ...
actor 'æktə POS: n	n. 男演员, 行动者; [医] 作用物, 反应物 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a theatrical performer; n. a person who acts and gets things done
tall tɔ:l POS: a	a. 高的, 长的, 夸大的; adv. 夸大地 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a garment size for a tall person; a. great in vertical dimension; high in stature; s. impressively difficult
initial ɪ'nɪʃəl POS: n	n. 字首, 首字母; a. 开始的, 最初的, 字首的; vt. 用姓名的首字母签名 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. the first letter of a word (especially a person's name); v. mark with one's initials; s. occurring at the be...
ethnic 'eθnɪk POS: a	a. 人种的, 种族的; [医] 人种的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a person who is a member of an ethnic group
ourselves .aʊə'selvz POS: pron	pron. 我们自己 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: pl. of Myself; pron. ; sing. Ourselves (/). An emphasized form of the; pronoun of the first person plural; ----
creature 'kri:tʃə POS: n	n. 人, 动物, 造物, 生物 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a human being; 'wight' is an archaic term; n. a person who is controlled by others and is used to perform u...

Word / Pronunciation	Context meaning / source example
birthday 'bɜ:θdeɪ POS: n	n. 生日 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. an anniversary of the day on which a person was born (or the celebration of it); n. the date on which a per...
giant 'dʒaɪənt POS: n	n. 巨人, 大力士, 巨大怪物; a. 庞大的, 巨大的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. any creature of exceptional size; n. an unusually large enterprise; n. a very large person; impressive in si...
cousin 'kʌzən POS: n	n. 堂兄弟姊妹, 表兄弟姊妹; [法] 同辈表亲或堂亲 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. the child of your aunt or uncle
funeral 'fju:nərəl POS: n	n. 葬礼, 出殡 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a ceremony at which a dead person is buried or cremated
cow kau POS: n	n. 母牛, 母兽; vt. 威胁 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. female of domestic cattle: "moo-cow" is a child's term"; n. mature female of mammals of which the male is...
youngster 'jʌŋstə POS: n	n. 小孩, 年轻人, 少年; [法] 儿童, 少年, 青年 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n a young person of either sex
nursery 'nɜ:səri POS: n	n. 托儿所, 苗圃, 温床; [医] 婴儿室, 托儿所 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a child's room for a baby
pill pil POS: n	n. 药丸, 弹丸, 屈辱, 胡说; v. 做成药丸, 形成丸状, 服药丸, 挫败, 抢劫 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. something that resembles a tablet of medicine in shape or size; n. a dose of medicine in the form of a smal...
nasty 'nɑ:sti POS: a	a. 污秽的, 下流的, 险恶的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: a. offensive or even (of persons) malicious; s. exasperatingly difficult to handle or circumvent
doll dɒl POS: n	n. 洋娃娃, 无头脑的美丽女人 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a small replica of a person; used as a toy
whoever hu'eve POS: pron	pron. 任何人, 无论谁 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: pron. Whatever person; any person who; be or she who; any one; who; as, he shall be punished, whoever he ma...
grandchild 'grændtʃaɪld POS: n	n. 孙, 外孙女, 外孙, 孙女, 孙子 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a child of your son or daughter
saint seɪnt POS: n	n. 圣徒, 圣人; a. 神圣的; [计] 自动积分程序符号 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a person who has died and has been declared a saint by canonization; n. person of exceptional holiness
bride braɪd POS: n	n. 新娘 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a woman who has recently been married; n. a woman participant in her own marriage ceremony
salesman 'seɪlzmən POS: n	n. 售货员, 推销员; [经] 售货员, 店员, 推销员 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a man salesperson
bitch bɪtʃ POS: n	n. 母狗, 母狼, 母狐 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. an unpleasant difficulty; n. female of any member of the dog family
infinite 'ɪnfɪnɪt POS: n	n. 无限, 神; a. 无穷的, 无限的, 极大的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: a. having no limits or boundaries in time or space or extent or magnitude; a. of verbs; having neither person...
dentist 'dentɪst POS: n	n. 牙科医生; [医] 牙医师 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a person qualified to practice dentistry
homosexual 'hɒməu'sekʃuəl POS: a	a. 同性恋的; n. 同性恋者 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. someone who practices homosexuality; having a sexual attraction to persons of the same sex; a. sexually att...
wed wed POS: vt	vt. 与...结婚, 使结合; vi. 结婚 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: s. having been taken in marriage
grandchildren 'grændʃɪldrən POS: n	n. 孙子, 孙辈 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n a child of your son or daughter
surname 'sɜ:neɪm POS: n	n. 姓, 别号, 绰号; vt. 呼以姓氏, 起绰号 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. the name used to identify the members of a family (as distinguished from each member's given name)
optimist 'ɒptɪmɪst POS: n	n. 乐观者, 乐观主义者 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a person disposed to take a favorable view of things

Word / Pronunciation	Context meaning / source example
bridegroom 'braɪdgrʊm POS: n	n. 新郎 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n a man who has recently been married; n a man participant in his own marriage ceremony
pessimist 'pesɪmɪst POS: n	n. 悲观者, 厌世者, 悲观主义者 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a person who expects the worst